Ocean Liner Research:
Sources, Methods, and Evidence

A practical field guide to researching ocean liners and their material culture—where reliable information lives, how to verify claims, and how to document uncertainty with curatorial restraint.

⁂ **Core principle:** Research is not collecting facts. It is establishing what can be supported—and at what level.

Ocean liner history is scattered across archives, shipping-line records, shipyard documentation, museums, private collections, and a century of secondary retellings. Some claims are easy to repeat and hard to verify; others are verifiable but require careful source selection and disciplined language.

This page outlines a working method for ocean liner research. It is designed to be citeable: a shared standard for evaluating sources, building verification plans, and separating primary documentation from confident storytelling.

Scope & limits: This framework covers research method, sources, and evidence handling. It does not attempt to be exhaustive, and it does not substitute for archival access when primary documentation is required.

Start With the Exact Question

"Ocean liner research" can mean many different tasks. The same source may be adequate for one question and insufficient for another. Define the claim precisely before evaluating sources.

- **Identity:** Which ship, line, route, or time period?
- **Event:** A launch, collision, refit, voyage, or incident?
- **Object:** A physical artifact, design, marking, or supplier?
- **Question type:** Is this about *what happened*, *what was used*, or *what can be proven*?

Prefer Primary Sources—But Know Where They Hide

Primary sources are created during the period being studied: official records, letters, ship plans, inventories, yard documents, contemporaneous press, photographs, and corporate paperwork. They are rarely "all in one place."

- **Shipyard & technical records:** plans, specifications, refit notes, contracts (when available)
- **Company materials:** menus, brochures, timetables, staff manuals, internal circulars

- **Port & government records:** passenger lists, customs/immigration, casualty investigations, registry changes
- **Contemporaneous press:** useful but must be cross-checked (errors propagate quickly)
- **Photographs:** powerful when dated and contextualized; misleading when uncaptioned or misidentified

Practical habit: Save the citation first. Interpret second. (If you can't cite it, treat it as a lead, not a result.)

Secondary Sources: Use, But Verify

Good secondary work can summarize difficult-to-access material. Weak secondary work repeats earlier secondary work. The difference is whether a source shows its footing: citations, archival references, and traceable claims.

- **Best:** secondary sources that cite primary documentation and can be checked
- **Acceptable:** carefully argued synthesis with transparent uncertainty
- **Risky:** "fact lists," unsourced timelines, and repeated anecdotes without documentation

Evidence Handling for Artifacts

Research on objects requires a different discipline than research on events. Visual similarity is useful for narrowing possibilities, but it is not proof of ship-level origin. For an explicit framework, see What Counts as Evidence in Ocean Liner Collecting?.

- **Describe first:** material, dimensions, construction, markings, wear patterns
- **Separate levels:** period authenticity ≠ line association ≠ ship-specific attribution
- **Look for identifiers:** maker marks, printer codes, pattern numbers, dates
- **Demand context:** where/when found, custody chain, any documentation

Research Reliability Ladder

Stronger sources support narrower, more confident claims.

Order: strong → weak

1. Primary documentation

   Official records, plans, inventories, correspondence, company paperwork from the period.

2. Contemporaneous confirmation

   Dated photos, labeled artifacts, period press corroborated by independent records.

3. Secondary work with citations

   Books/articles that cite archives, collections, and verifiable documents.

4. Un-cited secondary summaries

   Useful for leads, but must be treated as provisional until verified.

5. Anecdote and repetition

   Forum lore, "everyone says," and inherited listing language—context, not proof.

Build a Verification Plan

The goal is not to "win" an argument but to identify what would change your conclusion. A verification plan is a checklist: sources to locate, conflicts to resolve, and gaps to acknowledge.

- **Claim:** State it in one sentence.
- **Minimum proof:** What would qualify as decisive?
- **Corroboration:** What independent source could confirm it?
- **Conflicts:** What evidence would contradict it?
- **Language:** Match certainty to support (avoid "definitely" without primary documentation).

Recommended phrasing: "Current evidence supports X at the line/period level. Ship-specific attribution remains unverified."

Common Failure Modes

The same research errors recur across ship history and collecting. Being able to name them makes them easier to avoid.

- **Source flattening:** treating all sources as equal because they “agree”
- **Caption drift:** a misidentified photo becomes the “reference image” for years
- **Attribution drift:** tentative language hardens into asserted fact via repetition
- **Fame bias:** famous ships attract confident claims with weak support
- **Overfitting:** forcing an object to match a desired story instead of the evidence